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RESIDENTS of Beirut's suburbs flee after the Israeli army told them to "evacuate your homes immediately."

ISRAEL ATTACKS, BEIRUT AREA A WAR ZONE

By NABIH BULOS

BEIRUT — The Israeli military issued evacuation orders for entire neighborhoods of Beirut's southern suburbs, sparking pandemonium as hundreds of thousands of people joined a panicked exodus out toward Lebanon's north.

On Thursday afternoon, the Israeli military's Arabic-language spokesman told residents of the Dahiyeh — the Hezbollah-dominated southern suburbs of the Lebanese capital — to "save your lives and evacuate your homes immediately."

The evacuation order was unprecedented in scale, encompassing a 6-square-mile, densely populated section on the capital's southern edge. Although often described as a Hezbollah "stronghold," the Dahiyeh comprises four residential neighborhoods, with high-rises, commercial thoroughfares and restaurants, that are home to hundreds of thousands of Shiites but also Lebanese of other sects, refugees and migrants.

Soon after the announcement, motorists flooded the roads, with cars, trucks, scooters, motorcycles — anything with wheels. Beirut's traffic — a sham-bolic affair in the best of times — became even more chaotic, with motorists honking and shouting in a

[See Lebanon, A3]

War with Iran widens; Europe allies aid U.S.

Trump vows to select Tehran's next leader; House rejects reining in president's authority

By GAVIN J. QUINTON, NABIH BULOS AND ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — President Trump declared he would be "personally involved" in selecting Iran's next leader as U.S. and Israeli forces continued their bombardment of its government Thursday, even as officials in Tehran insisted they could withstand the war.

In a series of media interviews, Trump rejected the potential rise of Mojtaba Khamenei, son of assassinated Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei, calling him a "light-weight," and likened his own intended role in Iran's transition to the U.S.-backed installation of Delcy Rodríguez in Venezuela. He said at a White House event that the United States will ensure that "whoever leads the country next will not threaten America."

The statements came after reports

that the Pentagon is preparing for a longer conflict than initially projected by the Trump administration. The deepening crisis sent oil prices soaring Thursday past \$80 a barrel and caused the Dow Jones industrial average to tumble nearly 800 points.

"Iran is hoping that we cannot sustain this, which is a really bad miscalculation," Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said at a news conference at U.S. Central Command in Florida. "We have only just begun to fight and fight decisively. ... If you think you've seen something — just wait."

On its sixth day, the conflict continued to draw more nations into the fray, as Israel intensified strikes in Lebanon against Hezbollah militants, while Kurdish forces prepared

[See War, A3]

Paramount deal stokes job fears at CNN, CBS News

By STEPHEN BATTAGLIO

Paramount's \$3B-billion deal to acquire Warner Bros. Discovery will put two of the most storied journalism brands — CNN and CBS News — under one roof.

The combination has been proposed before with the aim of consolidating news-gathering costs. Those plans fell apart largely over who would be in control.

But if the Paramount-Warner transaction is approved by regulators, CNN and CBS News would be

forced into a potentially rocky marriage in which they would have to sort out leadership roles, personnel and editorial direction.

It's still too early to determine what those moves would be and how widely they would be felt.

Last week, CNN Chief Executive Mark Thompson told his troops to avoid "jumping to conclusions about the future."

But what is certain is that every permutation would be scrutinized closely because of the fraught relationships both CNN and CBS News

have with the Trump administration.

"There have been many conversations over the years about combining CBS News and CNN," said Jon Klein, a digital media entrepreneur who previously held leadership roles at both organizations. "But this time, it's different. The business case always made sense — but today you've got the overlay of the political agenda."

Before Paramount prevailed in its bid for CNN's parent, Paramount CEO David Ellison's father, Larry

[See Paramount, A12]

President fires embattled Noem as DHS secretary

Trump says he will replace her with GOP Sen. Markwayne Mullin of Oklahoma.

By ANDREA CASTILLO AND ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — In a major shake-up of the agency at the center of the Trump administration's immigration policies, President Trump announced Thursday that he was replacing embattled Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem, who will step down at the end of the month.

Trump said on his social media website that he will nominate Sen. Markwayne Mullin (R-Okla.) to take over the job, two days after Noem was grilled on Capitol Hill by Democrats and some Republicans.

Noem will become a special envoy for the Shield of the Americas, a new security initiative that Trump said would focus on the Western Hemisphere.

Noem, the former South Dakota governor, is the first Cabinet secretary to leave during Trump's second term as president. Her departure comes amid intense scrutiny over immigration enforcement tactics since last year that intensified after the shooting deaths of two protesters in Minneapolis by immigration agents, which she called domestic terrorism without evidence.

Those killings led to demands for more accountability within the agency, and disagreement over how to rein in the tactics deployed by federal immigration agents has led to a weeks-long standoff over the agency's funding.

Since the shutdown, lawmakers from both parties have used a series of contentious oversight hearings to question Noem's management of the agency. During a hearing Tuesday, the criticism from Republicans was particularly blunt.

"We are an exceptional nation, and one of the reasons we are exceptional is because we expect exceptional leadership, and you've demonstrated anything but that," Sen. Thom Tillis (R-N.C.) told Noem.

When Trump announced the shake-up on social media, Noem was speaking at a conference in Nashville. She answered questions from local law enforcement organizations, and did not offer hints that she knew her departure was imminent. She was not asked about her firing.

After the conference ended, Noem thanked Trump on X for her special envoy appointment, a diplomatic position she said will have her working to prevent drugs from coming into the United States.

"I am super excited about this opportunity. It came as not a complete surprise, but it came as a little bit of a surprise," Mullin told reporters

[See Noem, A6]



HEATHER DIEHL Getty Images

BEFORE her dismissal, Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem faced a grilling from lawmakers.

No thinning out in governor's race

Democratic Party head's call for some candidates to bow out goes unheeded.

By NICOLE NIXON AND SEEMA MEHTA

SACRAMENTO — Despite a plea from the head of the California Democratic Party for underperforming candidates to drop out of the governor's race, all but one of the party's top hopefuls spurned the request.

Party leaders fear the growing possibility that the crowded field will split the Democratic electorate in the state's June top-two primary election and result in two Republicans advancing to the November ballot, ensuring a Republican governor being elected for the first time since 2006.

His advice largely unheeded, state party Chairman Rusty Hicks on Thursday said the fate of a Democratic victory now rests squarely on the gubernatorial candidates who flouted him.

"The candidates for Governor now have a chance to showcase a viable path to win," Hicks said in a statement Thursday.

Eight top Democratic candidates filed the official paperwork to appear on the June ballot after Hicks released a letter on Tuesday urging those "who cannot show meaningful progress towards winning" to drop

out. Friday is the deadline to file to appear on the primary election ballot.

"It sounded like someone who has his head in the sand," former Los Angeles Mayor Antonio Villaraigosa said of Hicks' open letter. "[Most] of us filed within 24 hours of getting that letter. It created some press but not much else. It didn't impact [most] of the candidates and it certainly didn't impact my candidacy."

Democratic strategist Elizabeth Ashford said it was appropriate for Hicks and other Democratic leaders to make a public plea as opposed to keeping such discussions solely behind closed doors.

But the response showed the limited power of the modern-day party bosses.

"It's definitely not Tammany Hall," said Ashford, referring to the storied Democratic political machine that had a grip on New York City politics for nearly a century. "The party and Rusty are influential and they are helpful and that is their role. I don't think anyone would be comfortable with outright public strong-arming of specific candidates."

Ashford, who worked for former Govs. Jerry Brown and Arnold Schwarzenegger, along with former Vice President Kamala Harris when she served as state attorney general, added that the minimal power of the state GOP is likely a factor in the dynamics of Democrats' decision to stay in the race.

[See Primary, A6]

Town scarred by day of terror

Etzatlán, Mexico, picks up pieces and seeks answers after retaliatory attacks for killing of 'El Mencho'

By Keegan Hamilton



FELIX MARQUEZ For The Times

A BURNED PEMEX gas station along the highway connecting Guadalajara and Etzatlán in Mexico.

ETZATLÁN, Mexico — There are two sides to the town on Jalisco's tequila trail.

One is the charming pueblo in foothills lined with neat rows of agave cactus. In the central plaza you'll see swaths of handwoven fabric draped like canopies over the cobbled streets — splashes of pink, blue, yellow and green offering welcome shade from the afternoon heat. Locals boast that their *cielo tejido* is world-famous, and once even went on display in Dubai.

The other version of Etzatlán is one most people are scared to talk about.

It's the place where cartel foot soldiers torched the gas station last week, along with the bus depot, a state-run bank and dozens of vehicles, leaving residents hiding in their homes during a 24-hour reign of terror.

Many remain fearful in the aftermath, left wondering whether a sense of normalcy will ever return and venting frustration with lo

[See Etzatlán, A4]

Possible help for water crisis

Carlsbad desalination plant key to proposal that would give states access to more river water. **CLIMATE, A9**

Authorities take on street gang

Indictment targets alleged members of 18th Street, one of whom is said to be its No. 2. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Stocks plummet as oil costs soar

Because of war in Iran, the price of crude has spiked to its highest level since summer 2024. **BUSINESS, A12**

Weather

Lots of sun. L.A. Basin: 77/57. **B6**

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